



Microscopic
view of
duckweed

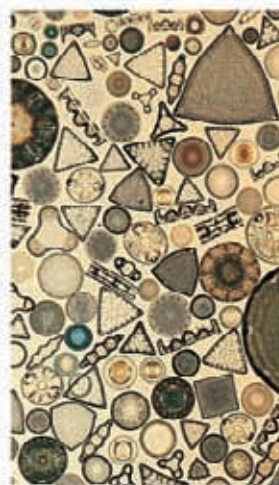
THE BIGGEST AND THE SMALLEST
The world's most massive plants are conifers—the giant sequoias of California, which can reach heights of more than 300 ft (95 m). The smallest flowering plant is the rootless duckweed, which is $\frac{1}{100}$ in (0.3 mm) across.



Ribbonlike plant body,
or thallus, divides into
branches as it grows

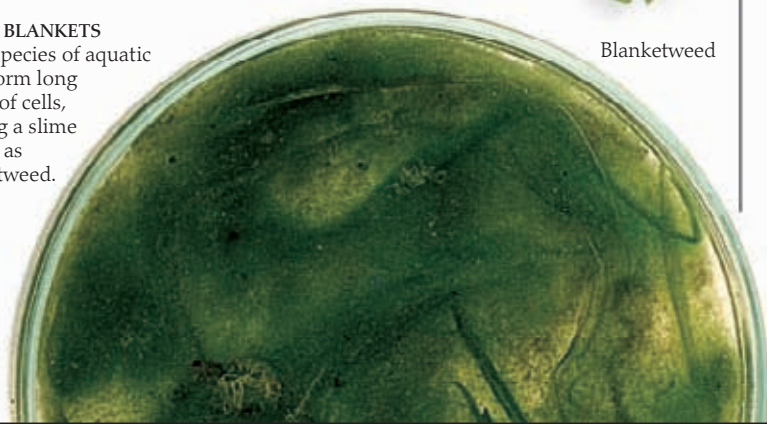
LIVERWORTS
Liverworts are nonflowering plants that live in damp places and reproduce by means of spores.

MOSES
Mosses do not have flowers. Like liverworts, mosses reproduce by means of tiny spores.



LIVING SCULPTURES
Algae are simple, nonflowering plants. A diatom is a single-celled alga, which has a rigid transparent case, or frustule, made of silica, a glasslike substance. This microscope image shows many species of diatom, each of which has a frustule of a different shape and pattern.

GREEN BLANKETS
Some species of aquatic algae form long chains of cells, creating a slime known as blanketweed.



Blanketweed



Garden pansy

FLOWERING PLANTS
Unlike the other plants on these two pages, flowering plants have true flowers. They are unique in having seeds that develop inside a protective structure called an ovary (p. 17), which later becomes a fruit (pp. 26–27). The garden pansy is a typical flowering plant.